

MiniLicensePlates.com

Pre-deployment checklist for WHM / cPanel — read before changing anything on the server

Purpose: Work through this checklist in the break room before uploading files or changing live settings. This app is **Laravel 12** and requires **PHP 8.2 or newer**. Your legacy site can stay on an older PHP version on the *same server* as long as each domain uses the correct PHP version in cPanel.

Not in Git: .env, vendor/, public/plates/, and MySQL data must be handled separately.

Overview — what lives where

Item	In Git?	How it reaches production
Laravel code, views, CSS, banners	Yes	Git clone, ZIP upload, or deploy script
.env (secrets, DB, mail)	No	Create manually on server
vendor/ (Composer packages)	No	composer install on server (needs SSH usually)
public/plates/ (plate photos)	No	ZIP, File Manager, or rsync
MySQL data (plates table, etc.)	No	phpMyAdmin import or mysqldump

PHASE 1 WHM (root / reseller access)

Skip Phase 1 if you only have cPanel access for your domain account.

1.1 PHP versions installed

Where: WHM → Software → **EasyApache 4** (or **MultiPHP Manager**)

- ☐ Is **PHP 8.2** or **8.3** installed?
- ☐ Which old PHP version runs the legacy site? (e.g. 5.6, 7.2, 7.4)

Installed PHP versions (write here):

1.2 PHP extensions for Laravel (PHP 8.2+)

Where: EasyApache 4 → PHP Extensions for PHP 8.2/8.3

- ☐ mysqlnd / PDO MySQL
- ☐ mbstring, xml/dom, curl, zip, openssl
- ☐ fileinfo, bcmath, tokenizer, json

PHP 8.2+ available? Missing extensions?

1.3 SSH and Composer

Where: WHM → Security Center → Shell Access (or ask host)

- ☐ SSH enabled for your cPanel user?
- ☐ Composer available on server? (Often not preinstalled.)

If you have SSH, run these and note the output:

```
php -v
which composer
composer -V
```

SSH: yes / no | Composer: yes / no

PHASE 2 cPanel (your domain account)

Log into cPanel for the domain that will run the **new** Laravel site.

2.1 Choose the domain

- ☐ **Main domain** — replaces legacy when ready
- ☐ **Subdomain first** (recommended) — e.g. new.yourdomain.com OR beta.yourdomain.com

Domain / subdomain I will use for Laravel:

2.2 PHP version for the new site

Where: cPanel → Software → **MultiPHP Manager** (or Select PHP Version)

- ☐ Set the **new** domain/subdomain to PHP **8.2** or **8.3**
- ☐ Leave the **legacy** domain on its old PHP version

Also check: MultiPHP INI Editor — note `memory_limit` (256M+ ideal), `upload_max_filesize`, `post_max_size`.

PHP version for new domain | memory_limit | upload_max_filesize

2.3 Document root (critical for Laravel)

Where: cPanel → Domains (or Domains → Subdomains)

Laravel must be served from the **public** folder inside the project — not the project root.

Setup	Typical document root
Subdomain for testing	/home/user/minilicenseplates/public

Setup	Typical document root
Main domain (later)	/home/user/public_html/public after rearranging files

Legacy domain document root:

New Laravel domain document root (current or planned):

2.4 Legacy site — do not break yet

Legacy domain | document root | PHP version

2.5 MySQL database

Where: cPanel → Databases → MySQL Databases

- ☐ Create a new database (e.g. user_minilp)
- ☐ Create a database user with ALL PRIVILEGES on that database
- ☐ Note the hostname (usually localhost on cPanel)

MySQL hostname | database name | user created: yes/no

2.6 SSL (HTTPS)

Where: cPanel → Security → SSL/TLS Status (or Let’s Encrypt)

- ☐ SSL active for the domain/subdomain you will use?
- ☐ https://yourdomain.com loads without certificate warnings?

SSL working: yes / no

2.7 Home directory layout

Where: cPanel → File Manager

Recommended layout:

```
/home/username/  
public_html/           ← legacy site (leave alone for now)  
minilicenseplates/     ← Laravel project root (not directly web-accessible)  
  app/  
  public/              ← point subdomain document root HERE
```

```
storage/  
...
```

cPanel home path (e.g. /home/username/):

Test on subdomain first: yes / no

2.8 Cron jobs (optional for now)

Where: cPanel → Advanced → Cron Jobs

Laravel may later use: `* * * * * cd /path/to/project && php artisan schedule:run`

Cron available: yes / no

2.9 Email (contact / newsletter forms)

Where: cPanel → Email

- ☐ Does PHP `mail()` work on this server?
- ☐ Or do you use SMTP? (note host/port — do not write passwords here)

Mail method: PHP mail / SMTP / unknown

PHASE 3 Quick tests (before uploading Laravel)

3.1 PHP version test

In File Manager, create a temporary file in the **new** domain's document root:

```
<?php phpinfo();
```

Visit it in the browser. Confirm PHP **8.2+** and required extensions. **Delete the file immediately.**

PHP version shown on new domain:

3.2 URL rewriting (mod_rewrite)

Laravel needs `mod_rewrite` (Apache). Check `phpinfo` or cPanel Apache Modules.

Web server: Apache / Nginx / both | `mod_rewrite`: yes / no

PHASE 4 Capabilities summary

- ☐ SSH access
- ☐ phpMyAdmin for database import
- ☐ Git on server (Terminal: `git --version`)
- ☐ Preferred upload method: SSH / Git / ZIP / File Manager

Reply template — fill in and bring back

```
WHM / server:
- Installed PHP versions:
- PHP 8.2+ available: yes/no
- SSH enabled: yes/no
- Composer on server: yes/no

Legacy site:
- Domain:
- Document root:
- PHP version:

New Laravel site:
- Domain/subdomain I will use:
- Document root (current or planned):
- PHP version set to:
- SSL working: yes/no

MySQL:
- Hostname:
- Database created: yes/no (name: ____)
```

cPanel account home path:

Preferences:

- Test on subdomain first: yes/no
- File upload method: SSH / Git / ZIP / File Manager

Other:

- Apache or Nginx:
- mail() or SMTP:

What happens after this checklist

1. Create subdomain and point document root at `.../public`
2. Create production database and `.env`
3. Upload code and run `composer install --no-dev`
4. Import local MySQL dump and upload `public/plates/`
5. Set permissions on `storage/` and `bootstrap/cache/`

6. Test on subdomain, then switch main domain when ready
7. Set up one-click deploy (Git push + script or GitHub Action)

MiniLicensePlates.com — docs/DEPLOYMENT_CPANEL_CHECKLIST.html — generated for pre-deployment review